

DOES SCIENCE WORK AGAINST NATURE?

“Science is not a company or a country, but a process”

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“Let’s stop pretending that science doesn’t matter”

MICHAEL SPECTER SCIENCE AUTHOR

We tend to think that the arts provoke controversy. In truth, science causes more controversy these days. Back in the 1960s and '70s, the World Bank, in its infinite wisdom, came up with a bold scheme of constructing high-rise flats on the outskirts of Jakarta and offering those to poor slum dwellers. But they offered something else too: a completely foreign approach to life. The fallout wasn't happy. People hated the Western approach of habitation imposed upon them and went back to the slums. The lesson to me is clear: if you don't pay attention to local culture, your high-minded intentions have

no value and they often cause harm. Right now, this is true for the controversy around food—which way to approach agriculture, the use of industrial production and genetically-engineered products. Many people critique this and refer to it as “genetically modified” (GM) food. But, then all the food that we eat is genetically modified by thousands of years of farming! There were no tangerines in the Garden of Eden, for instance. We made it all.

The idea of producing food through genetic engineering brings more precision and more risks. But we rarely mention the benefits. A mistake, because there will be 9 billion people on this planet by 2050 and we will need to produce 70 to 100 per cent more food than we do now. And we have to do it in a way that it is sustainable, nutritious, doesn't harm the planet and meets the growing challenges of climate change. But science is often ignored in a barrel of emotions. Consider the decision of the Government of India to ban Bt brinjal.